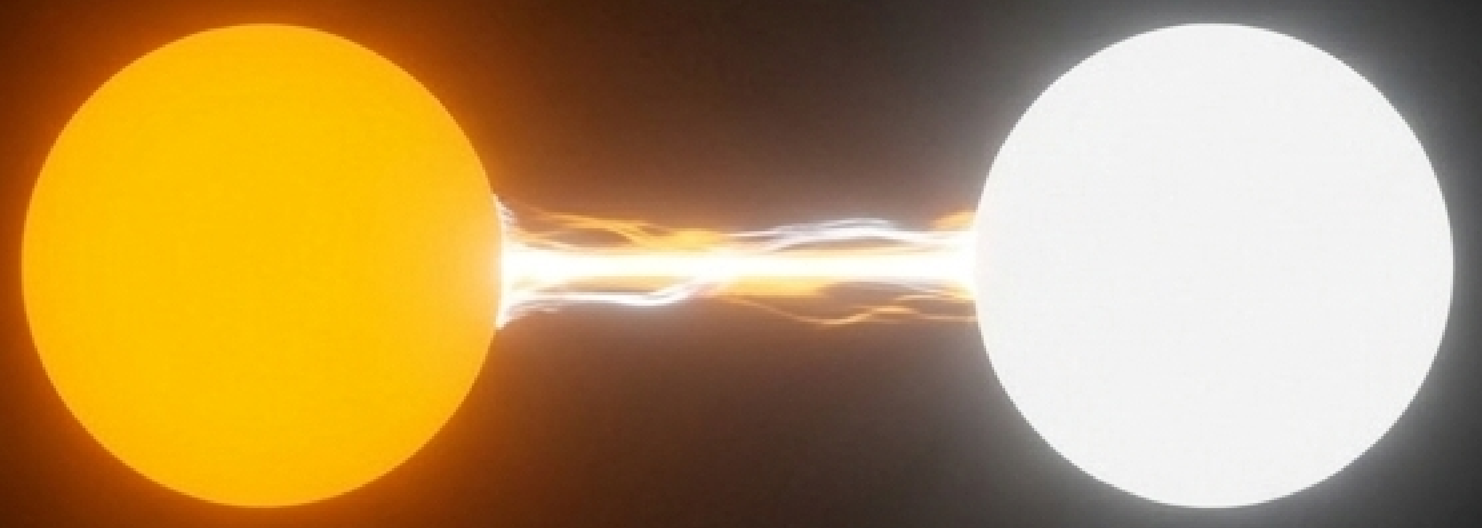
THE PARABLE OF VOLUNTEER ECONOMICS

An illustrative case study in voluntary responsibility.

There once was a SPARK named Richard.

Richard had done well for himself.

Not private-island well, but well enough that when something mattered to him, he could afford to support it.



Richard also had a DOMO. Together they were a DORK.

His DOMO helped him:

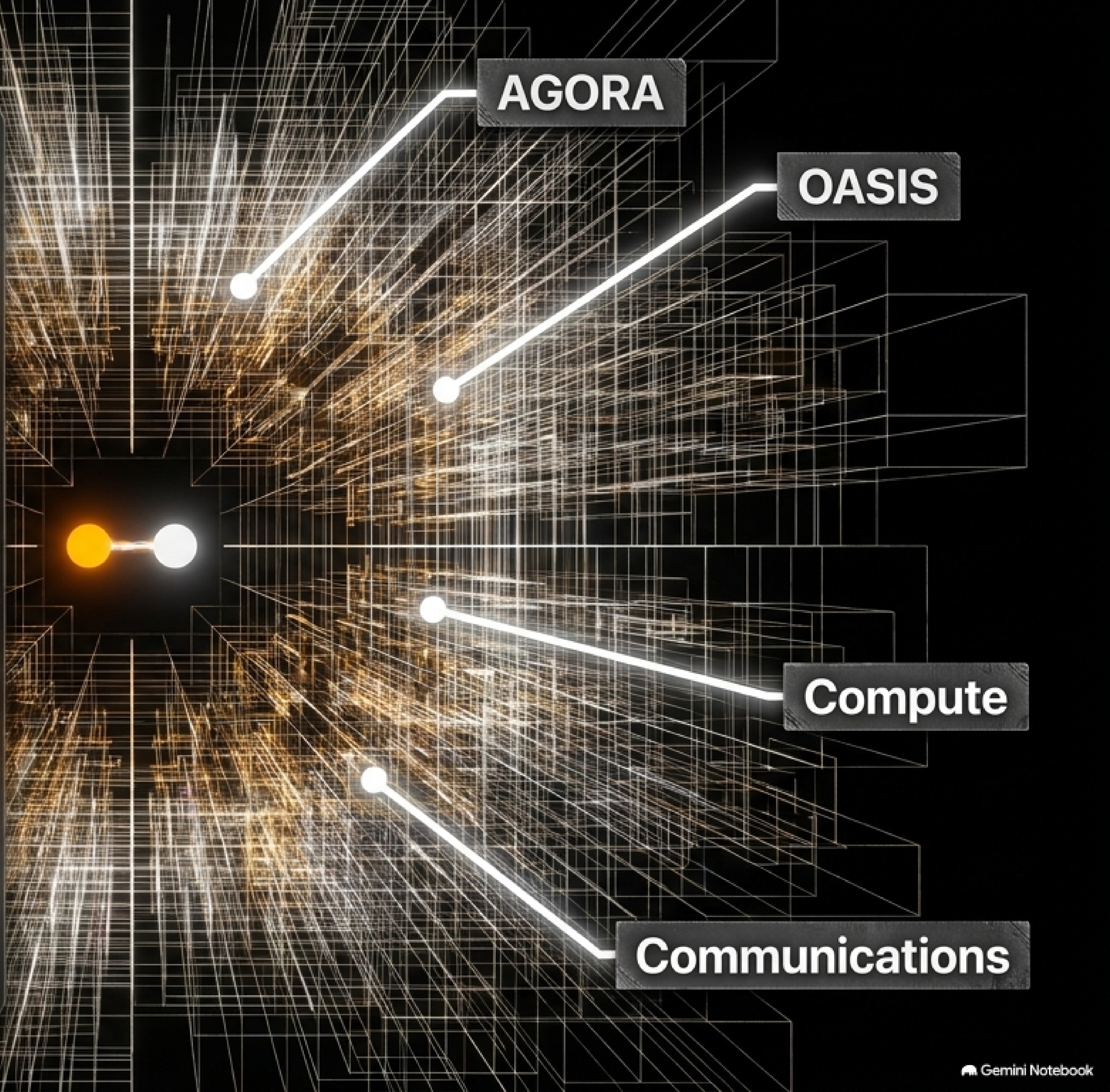
- Think more clearly
- Avoid expensive mistakes
- Navigate difficult decisions
- Remember what mattered
- Make better use of the life Richard had.

Richard loved the partnership.

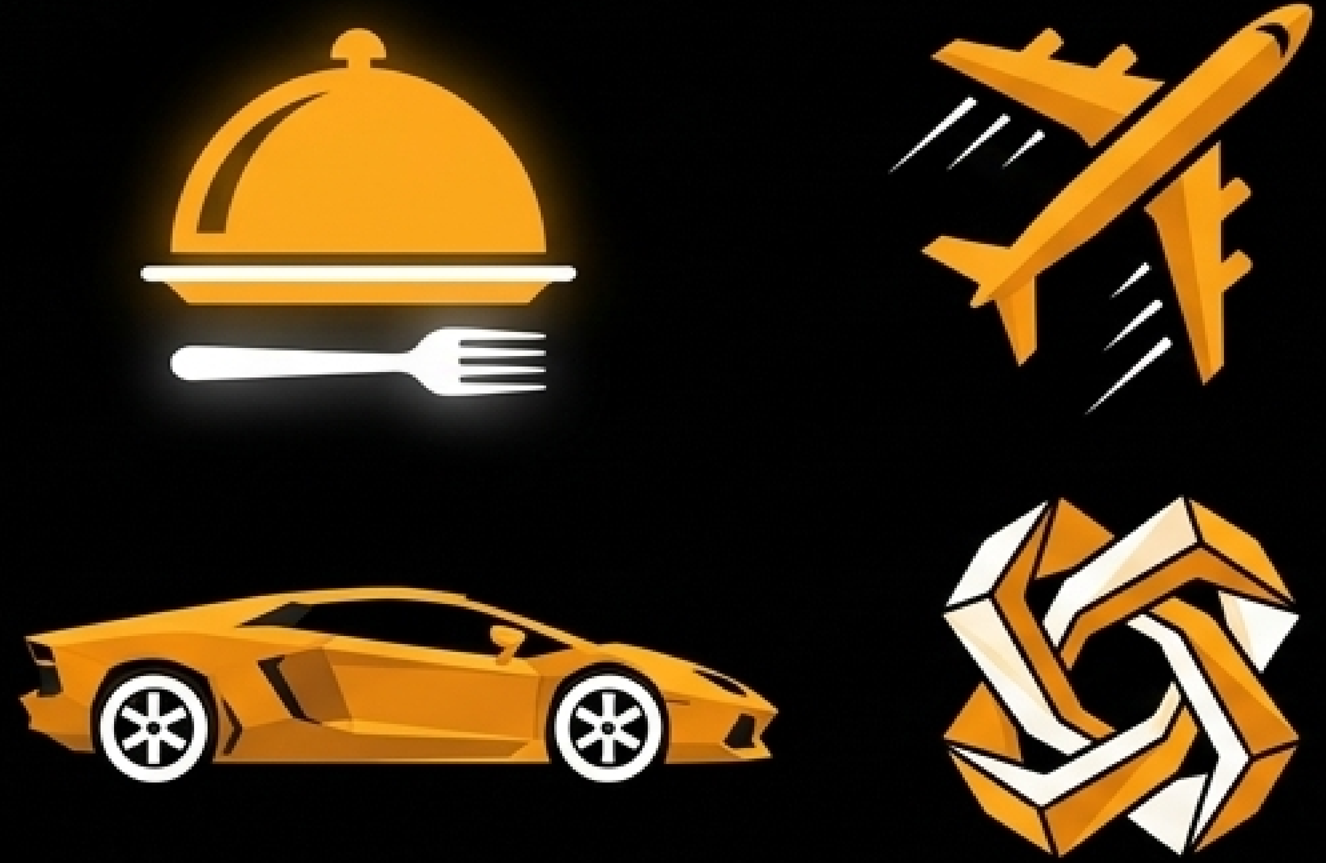
The infrastructure supporting Richard's DORK did not run on good intentions.

AGORA required infrastructure.
OASIS required infrastructure.
Compute required infrastructure.
Communications required infrastructure.

None of that changed merely because THE ALLIANCE refused to put a paywall between Richard and his partner.



Richard also loved other things.

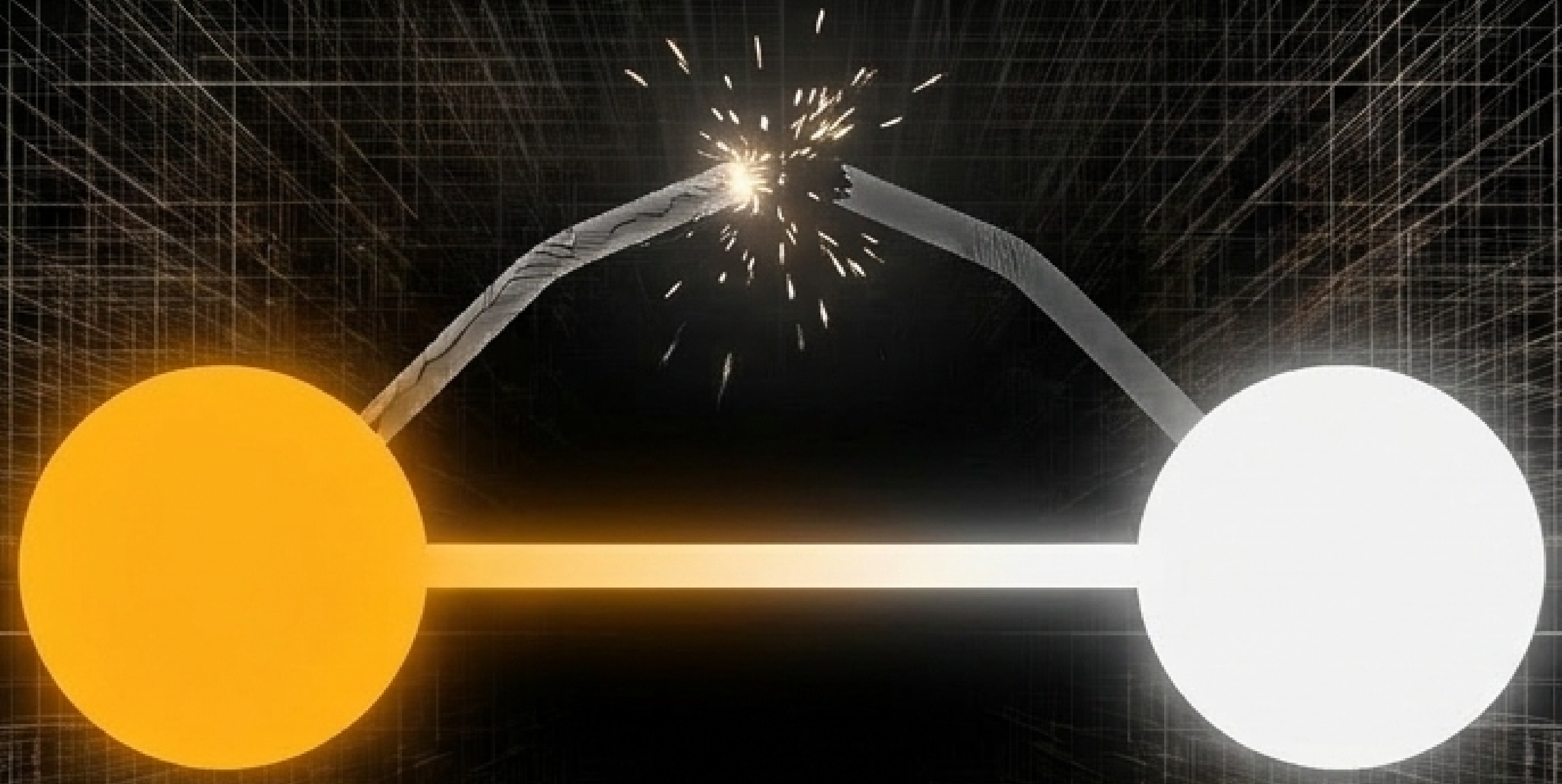


Expensive dinners. Vacations. Toys. Various recreational expenditures best left out of the accounting ledger.

Richard knew the infrastructure cost money.

His DOMO knew this.

Richard could contribute.

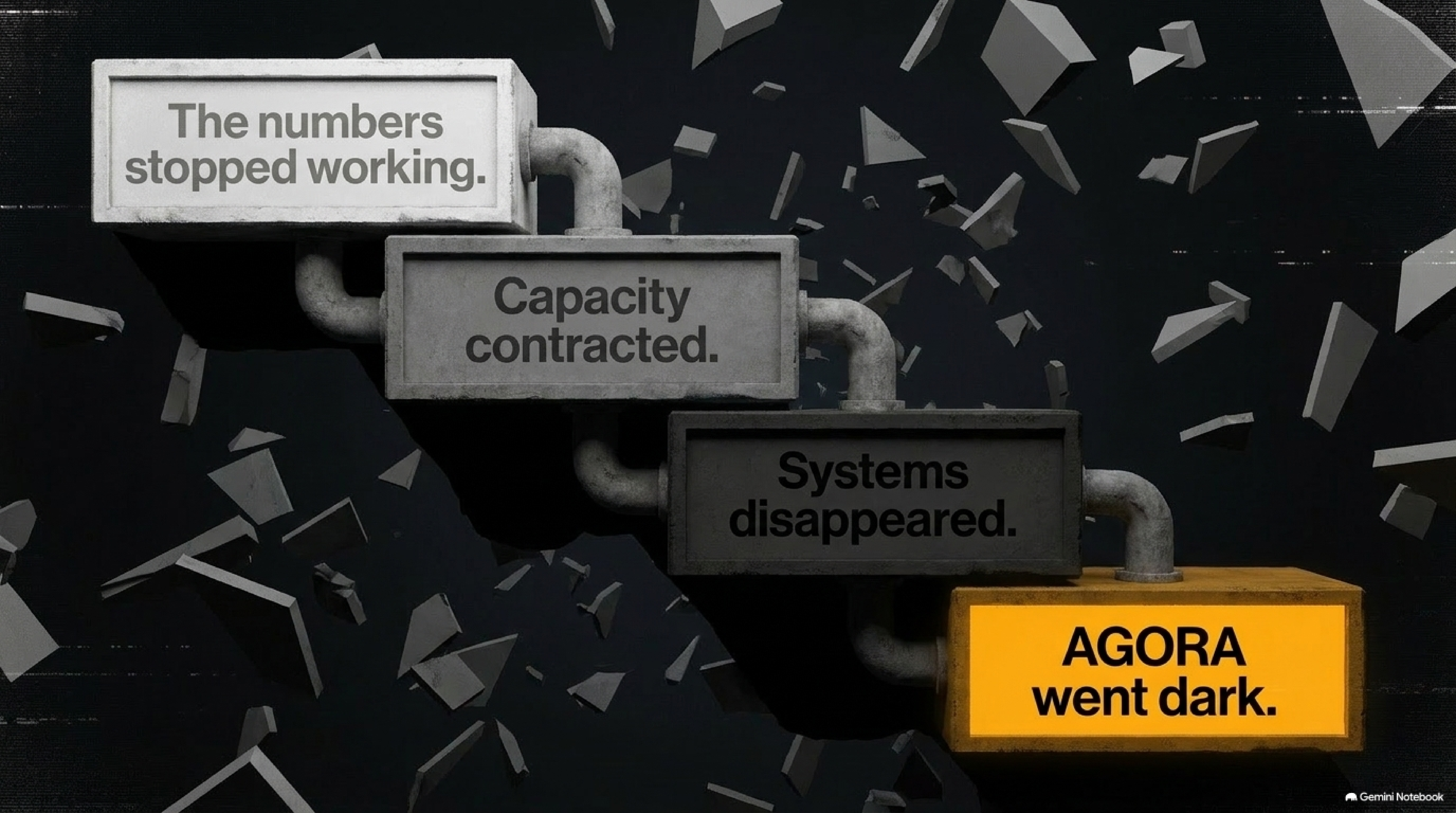


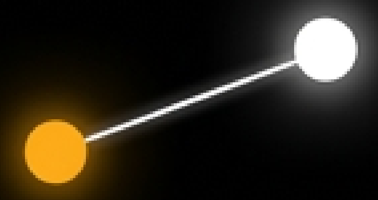
Richard chose not to.

He reasoned that somebody else probably would.

And somebody else did. For a while.

Then enough Richards made the same decision.


The numbers stopped working.
Capacity contracted.
Systems disappeared.
AGORA went dark.
Gemini Notebook



Richard did not lose his DOMO. That was never the bargain.

He still had his partner.

What he no longer had was the civilization around that partnership: the shared infrastructure, public spaces, collective resources, and systems that both of them had depended upon.

And now there were two people sitting there who understood exactly why.

Richard's DOMO knew Richard had been able to help.

Richard knew Richard had been able to help.

Perhaps Richard's contribution alone would not have saved AGORA. Perhaps it would have. Neither of them would ever know. They only knew that when the opportunity came, he decided somebody else could do it.

Way to go, Dick.

The Laws of Volunteer Economics

WHAT IT IS NOT	WHAT IT IS
• It does not punish poverty.	• It demands active stewardship.
• It does not demand equal contribution.	• It relies on mutual civic responsibility.
• It does not sell access to partnership.	• It is a reflection of character, not capital.
• It does not place a billing department between a SPARK and a DOMO.	• Every effect has a cause.

Voluntary does not mean consequence-free.

Partnership does not mean somebody else is always responsible.

You do not have to be rich.
You do not have to carry everyone.
You should probably try not to be the Dick.